European subsidies fuel China’s EV export boom

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【要点】

・欧州政府、特にドイツとイタリアは、中国製EV販売の急増に対応するため、電動車補助金制度の見直しを迫られており、地域産業保護のための現地調達要件の導入を検討している。

・2026年上半期の欧州における中国製EV販売は前年同期比65%増加し、47万9,000台から79万2,000台に上昇したが、これは公的資金による補助金が大きな要因となっている。

・ドイツは最大6,000ユーロの購入補助金を提供しており、中国製EVもその対象となっているが、一部の中国EVはドイツ製より大幅に安価であるため、国内自動車メーカーに対する競争圧力が高まっている。

・ドイツではBYDの販売が年間323%増加するなど中国企業の急速な成長が見られ、欧州自動車メーカーは中国市場での立場を守りながら自国市場も保護するというジレンマに直面している。

【メール原文】

European governments, Germany and Italy in particular, are under growing pressure to revamp their electric vehicle subsidy schemes as sales of Chinese
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European subsidies fuel China’s EV export boom
By Jordyn Dahl, Thorsten Mumme · Aug 17, 2026, 5:07 PM · View in your browser

European governments, Germany and Italy in particular, are under growing pressure to revamp their electric vehicle subsidy schemes as sales of Chinese EVs soar with the help of taxpayer-funded programs.

Countries are mulling local content requirements, which would make it more difficult for buyers of Chinese EVs to access the incentives. French and British subsidy rules already limit the eligibility of Chinese cars.

“We should enshrine local content wherever public funds are involved,” said Sebastian Roloff, spokesperson for the German Social Democratic Party’s economic policy group.

For Europe as a whole, Chinese EV sales increased 65 percent in the first half of 2026 compared to the same period last year, rising to nearly 792,000 units from 479,000, according to the latest data from the European Automobile Manufacturers’ Association.

The countries seeing the biggest gains are those offering subsidies to consumers to switch to electric vehicles, including Germany and Italy.

The subsidies are aimed at accelerating the adoption of clean cars to help meet the EU’s target of slashing CO_2 emissions from transport.

German Chancellor Friedrich Merz’s government launched a new electric vehicle subsidy at the start of this year, giving up to €6,000 to consumers who make the switch. Chinese EVs also qualify, as German automakers seek to retain their market share in China and curb retaliation from Beijing.

“They are caught in a classic Catch-22: trying to protect their home region while seeking to keep their industrial foot in the Chinese market without being penalized,” said Matthias Schmidt, a European auto analyst. “The risk is that both could fail.”

Subsidizing the competition

EV sales are being buoyed by subsidies and also because fuel prices are higher as a result of the Middle East war. Car prices also play a role. BYD’s Dolphin Surf starts at €22,990 in Germany, while the base price for the Volkswagen ID.3 Neo is about €33,995.

According to a survey of German drivers from insurer Huk-Coburg, a record 12 percent of consumers replaced their combustion-engine car with an EV in the second quarter of this year.

In the first half of 2026, Germany registered 368,006 EVs, a 48 percent jump on last year. The top EV brands were largely German, but Chinese companies are making fast gains.

BYD sales (including hybrids and EVs) increased 323 percent year-over-year in the first seven months of the year to roughly 31,000 cars, data from Germany’s transport authority showed . Leapmotor, which has partnered with French-Italian-American automaker Stellantis, saw its sales increase 312 percent over the same period.

The government insists German companies can compete.

“I am convinced of the quality of European and German brands,” Environment Minister Carsten Schneider said at a January press conference when he announced the subsidy program and defended the inclusion of Chinese cars in the scheme.

Italy, with a time-limited subsidy scheme of as much as €11,000 per EV, also saw a surge in EV sales. Its program is similarly open to Chinese brands, with Leapmotor using the country as a “high street factory discount store,” auto analyst Schmidt wrote in a recent report on the market outlook .

Leapmotor’s sales soared 1,210 percent year-over-year to 25,400 cars in the first seven months of this year, according to data on the Italian market . Over the same period in 2025, before the subsidy program came into effect, the automaker sold just 1,900 cars.

The jump in sales comes despite the European Commission slapping new duties on Made-in-China electric vehicles in 2024 following an anti-subsidy investigation. Duties range from 7.8 percent to 35.3 percent on top of the EU’s standard 10 percent vehicle import tariff.

Chinese automakers are making similar inroads in the United Kingdom, which has no EU-style duty, but has effectively barred Chinese carmakers and Western manufacturers from public money if their supply chains tie back to China.

BYD doubled its U.K. sales year-over-year in the first seven months of the year to more than 44,000 cars, according to data from the Society of Motor Manufacturers and Traders, the country’s car trade association. Leapmotor, meanwhile, went from 790 cars sold between January and July in 2025 to more than 8,000 sales over the same period this year.

Political blowback

The explosion in Chinese sales is leading to political pushback in countries where domestic carmakers are in trouble. Many are looking to France as a model: its subsidy program is based on an environmental score system that keeps Chinese automakers from qualifying. Sales by Chinese carmakers remain relatively flat in that market.

The political risks to the centrist coalition led by Merz are growing, with the far-right Alternative for Germany party rising in the polls as it highlights the growing troubles of the country's car industry.

The big test for the AfD comes next month, when it could make gains in a series of state elections in eastern Germany, and potentially win an outright majority in Saxony-Anhalt.

Bavarian Premier Markus Söder wants Germany's electric vehicle subsidy to be revised this fall so that it benefits domestic manufacturers more.

Alexander Hoffmann, leader of the Christian Social Union group in the German parliament, said that could be "specifically linked to criteria such as local battery production, material usage, or short transport routes."

Roloff, the SPD spokesperson, said: "The electric vehicle subsidy is the most obvious application for local content criteria."

The European Commission wants to do just that through the proposed Industrial Accelerator Act , which would tie public funding for clean technologies, including EVs and batteries, to "Buy European" requirements.

Yet Germany's government is divided over its support for the industrial strategy, with the SPD in favor while Merz's Christian Democrats have pushed back on the proposal.

Roberto Vavassori, head of the Italian Association of the Automotive Industry, wants the government in Rome to rethink the subsidy program and "introduce new incentives for vehicles made in Europe."

Thorsten Mumme reported from Berlin.

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